

DR. GLEN WALTON

(He/Him) · PhD (Research and Practice), Arts and Education · MSc (Research), Computing Sciences ·
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Glen makes participatory artworks that invite strangers to play, make music and collaborate with each other in public space. He founded **Playable Streets** in 2015 and has built it into an international company touring a growing repertoire of works. His practice draws on performance that is deeply relational and creative technologies that encourage human connection. Glen is also the co-founder of internationally acclaimed theatre company **The Suitcase Royale** and long time collaborator with **Polyglot Theatre**. He has recently completed a practice-based **PhD** examining the vital role of the creative facilitator in participatory art which shows how they open doors to public participation. Glen's work is driven by two things: giving people opportunities to be creative in their communities and public places, and making participatory practice a genuine pathway for emerging artists and producers.

SELECTED WORKS

The Musical Plants (2016 to present) transforms living plants into instruments by sensing the natural electrical charge in the human body. Presented at Esplanade Theatres on the Bay, Singapore for the March On festival (2024); Seoul Street Arts Festival and the Silk Road Festival, Seoul (2025); Busan, South Korea (2026); Arts Centre Melbourne (2024); Melbourne Recital Centre (2023); Joondalup Festival, Perth (2025); Port Fairy Folk Festival (2025); Dream Big Festival, Adelaide (2025); Cairns Children's Festival (2025); Floriade, Canberra (2024 and 2025); Begonia Festival, Ballarat (2026); Willoughby, Sydney (2026); Bunjil Place, St Kilda Festival, Geelong Arts Centre, Queenscliff, Whittlesea, Melton, Colac and many other regional and metropolitan councils and festivals.

Plant Sonata (2025 to present) is a long-term commission for Changi Airport, Singapore, installed in the Enchanted Garden in Terminal 2, where travellers make music by moving their hands near living plants using custom touchless sensors built for the site. It followed a seasonal Changi installation in 2024, is Playable Streets' first permanent public work, and was covered by STOMP Singapore after going viral in late 2025. A new expanded version is in development for installation in 2027.

ColdVoice (2024 to present) is a musical instrument made of ice that explores human intervention and glacial decline. Participants manipulate field recordings collected from Alaskan glaciers by touching ice directly, feeling cold through the skin as they compose. First commissioned by Monash Performing Arts Centres and presented in the David Li Sound Gallery (2025), then at Arts Centre Melbourne (2026). It is accompanied by *Glacier Swells*, a thirty minute eight-channel surround composition by Cayn Borthwick, and was developed as the practice component of Glen's PhD.

Reflection (2022 to present) is a large-scale interactive installation of brightly coloured mirror shapes that participants draw, write and 'reflect' on, seeing themselves in the context of the community around them. At night the work glows under ultraviolet light and the drawings become electric lines of colour. Presented at RISING, Melbourne (2023); Federation Square (2023); Moomba (2024); St Kilda Festival (2024); Queensland Music Festival (2024); Southside Festival (2025); Firelight Festival (2025); and across council festivals including Knox, Moonee Valley, Hume, Bayside, Wyndham, Greensborough and Queenscliff.

Duet Arts in Aged Care (2018 to present) brings professional artists into aged care settings to run participatory sound and music workshops with residents, many living with dementia. The first major project developed a new device allowing participants to make music together through interpersonal touch, created with Maroondah City Council and independently evaluated by Effective Change. The program has since run across facilities in Frankston, Mornington, Mount Eliza and beyond, including Seniors Festival programs, and has opened intergenerational exchange between younger artists and older participants with limited access to creative and social experiences. Recent funding from Dying to Know supports a new stage of the work, extending the interpersonal touch device into palliative care.

Exquisite Stories (2017 to present) turns children's drawings into an interactive installation of new characters with real recorded voices, taking the surrealist exquisite corpse game as its starting point. Developed with students of William Ruthven and Reservoir Primary Schools, supported by the City of Darebin, and presented at the Darebin Kite Festival, the State Library of Victoria and Cube 37, Frankston Arts Centre (2026).

Cubbytown, Kidstruments LIVE, BURROW, Sounding Stories, Reach Out Sounds, CLIPPY, Hug Me!, The Last Islands, Skylines & Storylines, Collab O Mations, Faces and Places, Clocks and **Playable Web** make up the rest of the repertoire, ranging from one-off installations to six-month community collaborations. Through PS Presents, Playable Streets also presents work by other independent companies, including *Endling* by Barking Spider Creative and *Musical Chairs* by Invisible Orchestra.

AWARDS

Green Room Award for Innovation in Contemporary Performance for Young People, 33rd Annual Green Room Awards, 2016, for *Separation Street*, a Polyglot Theatre and Suitcase Royale collaboration created with children from the Victorian College for the Deaf and Currajong Primary School, presented with Darebin Arts at Melbourne Fringe.

ARTIST PATHWAYS AND SECTOR DEVELOPMENT

Playable Streets operates entirely on self-generated income, with no ongoing or multi-year funding and no external backing. Glen has built the company into a sustained employment pathway for early-career artists, designers and producers: paying casual creative facilitators, engaging interns from RMIT, Deakin and VCA including a six-month international placement from Design Academy Eindhoven, and providing sustained work for emerging producers.

He is currently documenting the career pathways of established creative facilitators through the Playable Streets YouTube channel and the PS Playcast podcast. He is developing the **Creative Facilitator Summit**, a national gathering for artists working in participatory performance, to be held in April 2027 with ArtPlay and Arts Centre Melbourne.

Lecturer, Creative Technologies in Theatre, Deakin University, 2021 and 2022. **Mentor**, Creative Workers in Schools, Regional Arts Victoria, 2021, supporting creative workers placed in Victorian schools through coaching, individual and group conversations, and professional development workshops delivered across the state.

COMMISSIONS AND WORK IN DEVELOPMENT

- Children's Biennale, National Gallery Singapore, 2027 to 2028
- Creative Facilitator Summit, ArtPlay and Arts Centre Melbourne, February 2027
- Expanded Musical Plants installation, Changi Airport Singapore, 2027
- ColdVoice Monoliths and Kite Choir, in development

PRACTICE-BASED RESEARCH

PhD, *The Creative Facilitator: Practices within Outdoor Participatory Performance*, Faculty of Arts and Education, Deakin University, 2026. Through case studies, fieldwork and the development of a new participatory artwork (ColdVoice), this research theorises the creative facilitator role as a distinct practice. Supervised by Dr Rea Dennis.

MSc (Research), Computing Sciences, Creativity and Cognition Studio, University of Technology Sydney, 2018. Research into interactive touch-based musical installations, feeding directly into Playable Streets' early works.

PUBLICATIONS

- Walton, G., 2026. *The Creative Facilitator: Practices within Outdoor Participatory Performance*. PhD Thesis, Deakin University.
- Walton, G., Greuter, S. and Dennis, R., 2022. Exploring participant interaction with interpersonal touch musical interfaces. *Designing Interactive Systems Conference*, pp.28-31.
- O'Neil, M., Austin, H., Borthwick, C., Macindoe, A., Saulwick, T. and Walton, G., 2022. Sonic Touch: Charting connections in contemporary sound-led performance practice. *Performance Research*, 27(2), pp.64-71.
- Walton, G., 2018. *Designing interactive touch-based musical installations*. Masters Thesis, Creativity and Cognition Studio, UTS.
- Walton, G., 2016. Paper on the *In Touch* installation, OZCHI, Australian Conference on Human-Computer Interaction.

TALKS, RESIDENCIES AND DELEGATIONS

"The bridge to bring people in", ASSITEJ Singapore · "Strangers as collaborators", Pervasive Media Studio, Bristol · "Interactive technologies for musical collaboration", Technische Universität Berlin and SensiLab, Monash University · "Sound, Touch and Technology: New Pathways to Well-Being in Aged Care", ACRL, Melbourne

Children's Theatre Alliance delegate, Hong Kong 2026 · Pervasive Media Studio, Bristol, 2018 · Australian delegate, Ars Electronica, Linz, 2018 · Jacky Winter Gardens, 2018 · Cowwarr Art Space Garden Studio, 2017 · APAM, APAX, HKPAX and West Kowloon, Hong Kong, and Showcase Victoria market delegations

Glen lives, works and plays on the lands of the Bunurong people. Always was, always will be Aboriginal land.